



Samsung Nougat beta

The Android 7.0 Nougat Beta is out for the Galaxy S7 and S7 Edge. Official update release coming soon. <http://dgit.in/s7ug7>

CapitalG

Google capital changes name to CapitalG. It is the late-stage growth venture capital fund financed by Alphabet Inc. <http://dgit.in/capitlG>

economic benefits of recording music in Jamaican studios were not lost on European artists. Musicians including the Rolling Stones came to the island to record their albums. And when they returned to Britain and other parts of Europe, they took with them not only their finished album but also the influences of dub.



A dub musician and his machine

These influences later manifested in music that they created, which in turn gave rise to the underground 'dub-step' movement: music created by DJs in the British clubs, aggressive music designed to move people, much like what the pioneers of dub did for the people dancing in the open fields of Jamaica.

Enter hip-hop

After a decade or so, in the US, the DJ's console would issue the soundtrack for 'break-beat' dancing: a style of freestyle dancing pioneered on the streets by urban black kids of America.

There began live performances on street sides and garages- and a master of ceremony (MC) would introduce the DJ and the dancers to the audience. The MC would often 'rap' these introductions in a sing-song style. This was also around the time when 'scratch' music- the idea of producing music by scratching a vinyl record on a turntable- became popular.

It didn't take long for the MC's rap and the DJ's beats to give rise to an altogether new genre of music: hip-hop. And hip-hop went viral even before the concept of virality existed, so to speak. The genre is now popular throughout the world, including in India.

In other words, the infusion of technology in music that happened over 4 decades back in Jamaica still resonates- literally around the world.

Beyond what's heard – how technology is going beyond the auditory with music

The influence of technology on music is obviously an ongoing story, and we may assume that the pace of innovation would be higher in the future.

But one thing that looks extremely probable in this scenario is the death of the album format. The concept of picking individual songs and making a playlist of your own liking has already struck a chord with millions of people who use music playing software on their phones and other devices. The possibility of an entire people discovering the joys of listening to an entire album from start to finish seems remote.

But such a change, of course, is brought about more by the way music is distributed than how it's produced.

Touring hologram and other visual thrills for music

However, there is no doubt that the visual aspects of music performance would be changed dramatically with technology. Big names in the world of music have always been fascinated about upping the excitement of their live shows with the infusion of grand visual elements. You can go down the decades and revisit some of the live shows by Pink Floyd- one of the biggest rock bands ever. The kind of shows they put up during the 80s would give many a present day performer a run for their money.



Hip hop takes the stage

But these days, the album itself is becoming hybridized with visual offerings. Beyonce's 2016 album 'Lemonade' is a case in point in which the album was accompanied by the release of an hour long visual piece. The film shared the album's title and was divided into 11 chapters. It used poetry and prose written by the expatriate Somali poet, Warsan Shire and material created by other artists. The film was released on HBO.

In August 2016, Rapper Frank Ocean released a video titled 'Endless' which is termed as a visual album. It features new music and takes place in the same warehouse where the singer has been hosting a web stream. The visual album has twelve new songs and shows the artist patiently building a spiral staircase to the accompaniment of



Whitney Houston's hologram sung a duet with Christina Aguilera

music- among other things. The video was launched on Apple Music and is available only through the service.

But perhaps the most exciting of all visual inculcations in music is the resurrection of Whitney Houston- well, something close to that.

If you are a pop aficionado, you would recall that the singer passed away in 2009. But this year, she went on to perform live- to be more precise, her hologram performed live, singing a duet with Christina Aguilera. Some critics did find the hologram less than life-like, but what the project shows is that we are only scratching the surface of possibilities when it comes to innovating music visually with the aid of technology.

And whatever excitement is on the cards, we are eagerly waiting for it. 